

This chapter is intended to develop your understanding of *Mathematica* as a computer language. The chapter assumes that you have a general knowledge of how to use *Mathematica*. It concentrates on explaining some of the strategies and styles of *Mathematica* usage.

If you are familiar with other computer languages, reading this chapter should help you to understand the analogies, and differences, with *Mathematica*.

If *Mathematica* is your first computer language, you will probably not find this chapter particularly useful. If *Mathematica* is your second computer language, you should look at the section that compares *Mathematica* with your first language.

About the illustration overleaf:

This is a picture of a double helix, generated by the *Mathematica* command `Show[Graphics3D[DoubleHelix[]]]`. The function `DoubleHelix` is defined in the package `Shapes.m`. It returns a list of polygons which form a double helix.